ARTIST COMMONS

ART & AUTHORSHIP · SESSION 3B

What Makes It Mine?

Art & Authorship:
Authorship and Circulation

POST-SESSION TOOLKIT

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> If I didn't invent all the material, didn't make every part, and can't determine everything it means, in what sense am I its author?
>
> Four frameworks for examining a real contribution—and a decision you can try in the studio.

SESSION TOOLKIT

NAVIGATE THE TOOLKIT

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How to Use This Toolkit

Last session, we asked how original work can emerge from forms, materials, and histories that already exist. This session asks what it means to call that work yours.

You may have chosen and arranged existing material. Someone else's skill may have changed what you could make. Your experience may have made a detail visible to you. A publication, exhibition, score, or shared method may allow other people to do something they could not do before.

The four frameworks give us different ways to examine those contributions. They are not four requirements every artwork must meet. Where Quarter 2 asked how meaning operates and Session 3a asked about originality and lineage, this toolkit turns to attribution, position, collective activity, and conditions of use.

Begin with a finished or in-progress work. Read the section that gives you a useful question, then try an exercise. Work with studies, documentation, a passage, a score, or a small part of a larger project. The point is to make a decision easier to examine, not to account for every condition behind the work.

Understand
Overview, people from the session, artwork examples, and a specific complication.

Try
Three consecutive exercises: notice a relation, make a test, then develop what it reveals.

Read
Four free/open entry routes and four deeper readings in every framework.

Bring it together
A separate authorship map and glossary; choose one experiment, not a moral score.

01 The Author as Function

An artist's name helps connect works, shape expectations, and organize how the work is recognized and treated.

OVERVIEW

Michel Foucault's 1969 lecture *What Is an Author?* asks what happens when we identify someone as the author of a work. The answer is not exhausted by finding the person who made it. An author's name also helps organize the work's interpretation, its relation to other works, and the ways institutions handle it. Foucault calls this organizing role the **author-function**. Here, a function means a role something plays, not a job description for an artist.

Begin by distinguishing the person from the author. The person has a life, tries things, changes their mind, and makes particular decisions. The author we encounter in a catalogue or exhibition is an account constructed through works, statements, criticism, and records. When we say "she keeps returning to this question" or "this is an unusual departure for her," we connect individual works into a practice. That account may be illuminating, but it is selective. It is not identical to everything the person is or does.

Attribution therefore does several things at once. It groups works into a **body of work**. It gives us questions and expectations to bring to a particular piece. It also has practical consequences: a museum establishes whether an object belongs in an artist's exhibition; an archive files it under a name; a catalogue brings it into relation with other attributed works. These uses can reinforce one another without being the same activity.

Consider an experiment that seems not to belong in your portfolio. Perhaps it is a weak work. But perhaps your current account of your practice has no place for its humor, material, or scale. Rearranging the portfolio may reveal a relation that the familiar sequence concealed. Here, the author-function operates inside making as well as after it: "that isn't what I do" can rule out a possibility before you have tested it.

This is not advice to build a more consistent personal brand. Consistency may be precisely what needs examining. Nor does Foucault's argument mean that the maker's decisions are imaginary or irrelevant. It directs us toward the consequences of recognizing those decisions under a name. The useful studio question is not simply "Who made this?" but "What does identifying this person as its author lead us to connect, ask, include, or overlook?" An attribution supplies a context for looking. It does not supply the finished interpretation, and it remains possible for a new work to put the established account under pressure.

Thinkers and Artists from the Session

Michel Foucault

A French philosopher concerned with knowledge, power, and the formation of categories. His author-function describes what attribution does, rather than treating the author's biography as the final explanation of a work.

Andy Warhol and Sturtevant

Warhol's *Flowers* series and Sturtevant's repetitions return from Session 3a. We now ask how naming the artist places a closely related image within a different practice, rather than whether repetition can be original.





Left: Andy Warhol, Flowers, 1964. Offset lithograph. The Museum of Modern Art, New York; Frances R. Keech Bequest, 583.1994. Work/source record. **Right:** Sturtevant, work from the Warhol Flowers series. Image reproduced from the session.

The same resemblance, different connections

Place Warhol's flowers beside his soup cans and Marilyns. We may begin asking about familiar images, commercial printing, and repetition. Place Sturtevant's *Warhol Flowers* beside her repetitions of works by Duchamp or Johns. We have a different question: why would an artist repeatedly make another artist's work again?

The names do not make every visible similarity disappear. They change which other works seem relevant and what we think needs explaining. This is our application of Foucault's account, not a claim that either artist made the work to illustrate his theory.

When the Name Frames the Image

Martine Gutierrez

Gutierrez works across photography, video, performance, and music. In the artist magazine *Indigenous Woman*, she occupies roles a commercial publication usually distributes among many people, including model, photographer, stylist, editor, and publisher.



Martine Gutierrez, Queer Rage, Imagine Life-Size, and I'm Tyra, pp. 66–67 from Indigenous Woman, 2018; printed 2020. Crystal Bridges Museum of American Art, 2020.76. Work/source record.

Indigenous Woman is the publication as an artwork, not simply a magazine reporting on the artist. Fashion editorials, performed roles, and advertisements for invented products become parts of one project. Gutierrez's name helps connect them as decisions within that project. The spread's styling and pose then become things to examine, not merely commercial conventions to take for granted.

Where It Gets Complicated

Knowing the artist can sharpen attention or replace it. Calling this "Gutierrez's critique of fashion" gives us a useful possibility, but it does not yet explain what a particular image borrows, repeats, or unsettles.

Imagine an artist known for work about grief who begins making something playful. A viewer may still read the new work only through grief. That reading is not necessarily false; the problem is that the established account supplies the answer before the work can trouble it. The artist cannot correct this simply by writing a better statement. Reviews, exhibitions, earlier works, and other people's descriptions also sustain the expectation. You can test what you connect and foreground without pretending to control reception.

Studio Exercises

Three studio exercises: 1.1 Put a Practice Together · 1.2 Make the Exception · 1.3 What Did the Artist Context Add?

Exercise 1.1: Put a Practice Together

Choose several works or studies of your own, including one that feels difficult to place.

1. Arrange them as you usually would to explain your practice.
2. Make a second arrangement in which the difficult piece belongs. Change which works sit beside it or which pieces begin and end the sequence.
3. Write one sentence describing the practice each arrangement suggests.
4. Choose a connection from the second arrangement that could lead to another work or study.

The philosophical question: What we recognize as a body of work depends partly on how we connect its pieces. An apparent exception may expose the limits of our current account of the artist.

What the artist leaves with: Two arrangements and one connection to develop.

Exercise 1.2: Make the Exception

Complete the sentence: “Someone familiar with my work would expect me to _____.” Choose an expectation you recognize in your decisions, rather than inventing a hypothetical reputation.

1. Make a quick study that deliberately interrupts that expectation.
2. Keep enough of the original work or procedure to make the departure visible.
3. Put the study beside a work that fulfills the expectation.
4. Point to what the departure opens up. Decide whether it deserves another test, even if it initially feels unlike your work.

The philosophical question: The account of an artist can organize their own decisions as well as other people's interpretations. A departure can test that account.

What the artist leaves with: A new study and a reason to continue or set it aside.

Try It in the Studio

Exercise 1.3: What Did the Artist Context Add?

Choose one work and the short, accurate description of your practice that would normally accompany it.

1. Show the work first without that description. Ask a willing viewer what they notice and what makes them say so.
2. Introduce the description and one related earlier work. Ask what they now connect or expect.
3. Separate observations about the work from expectations supplied by the account of the artist.
4. Revise one presentation choice: the description, the accompanying work, or their order.

If no viewer is available, compare two mock presentations and record the questions each invites as hypotheses, not as evidence of another person's response. Keep authorship and provenance accurate throughout.

The philosophical question: Attribution supplies a context for looking, but it does not remove the need to look.

What the artist leaves with: A tested or explicitly provisional presentation change.

What the work supplied / What the artist context supplied

Record one observation tied to the work and one expectation introduced by the description or earlier piece. If you worked alone, label the expected response as a hypothesis.

What I will carry into the next version

Go Further with the Framework

Use the accessible list to enter the argument; the further readings support closer study and direct critiques. Free access does not always mean easy prose.

Accessible Reading List

1. The Open University — ***Foucault's author function (section 1.4 of Artists and authorship: the case of Raphael)***
   A short introduction to how criticism, myths, institutions, and legal categories construct authorship. Ask what an author-name enables and limits. Browser verification may be required. **Free text**
2. Paul H. Fry — ***Introduction (cont.) — Introduction to Theory of Literature, Lecture 2***
   Start with chapters 3–5: author and authority, founders of discursivity, and a critique of the author-function. Fry explains why authorship can organize discourse yet also matter to historically excluded speakers. **Free lecture + transcript**
3. Tim Spurgin — ***Reader's Guide to Foucault's 'What Is an Author'***
   A section-by-section guide to classification, attribution, the four characteristics of the author-function, and founders of discursivity. Its bookstore and disputed-Shakespeare examples make the construction of an author's corpus concrete. **Free text**
4. Paul Bové — ***Discourse (excerpt on the author)***
   Clarifies that questioning the author does not deny the writer's existence. Explains how complete editions, biographies, style, and critical institutions organize writing around an author and discipline what can be said about it. **Free text**

Further Reading

1. Adrian Wilson — ***Foucault on the 'Question of the Author': A Critical Exegesis***
   A close audit of Foucault's argument, distinguishing writer, author-figure, text, and work. Especially useful for testing whether corpus construction explains authorship or quietly presupposes the categories it claims to analyze. **Free PDF**
2. Cheryl Walker — ***Persona Criticism and the Death of the Author***
   A feminist revision retaining provisional author–work connections without an all-explaining genius. Walker's multiple persona resists biographical reduction and erased gendered authorship. Record and abstract are open; chapter download may require browser verification. **Free text**
3. Seán Burke — ***The Death and Return of the Author: Criticism and Subjectivity in Barthes, Foucault and Derrida, third edition***
   A sustained critique of anti-authorial theory from within its arguments. The Foucault discussion asks what—and who—an author is, exposing how authorial authority persists in accounts that announce its disappearance. **Library or purchase**
4. Michel Foucault — ***What Is an Author? (anthology selection)***
   The primary argument: an author's name classifies discourse, constructs a body of work, and regulates its circulation. Read the passages on attribution and Saint Jerome alongside your own portfolio decisions. **Free PDF**

02 Situated Authorship

Your particular encounter with the world shapes what you can notice and make. It also gives you something to investigate and revise.

OVERVIEW

Donna Haraway's 1988 essay *Situated Knowledges* begins with a problem about knowledge: how can we give a trustworthy account of the world when we always encounter it from a particular position? Bodies, training, relationships, instruments, and access shape what becomes available to notice. A microscope, a camera, a practiced hand, and a long relationship each make some things perceptible while leaving others outside their reach. These conditions do not merely distort an otherwise complete view. They help make knowing possible.

Haraway challenges the claim to see from nowhere, which she calls the **god trick**. Imagine a critic who explains an artist's judgment through the artist's upbringing, then says of their own judgment, "I just see things as they are." The critic has a history too, but exempts it from examination. One person's view becomes a situated perspective while the other person's view becomes the standard against which perspectives are measured.

The alternative is not that every account is equally good. A **partial perspective** can be responsible to evidence, open about the encounter that produced it, and capable of revision. You can ask what a claim is based on, what its methods reveal, and what might challenge it. Recognizing limits does not mean refusing to say anything definite. It means making a claim whose reach can be examined rather than claiming authority over the whole subject.

We are extending this account of knowledge to artistic authorship; Haraway is not offering a complete theory of authorship in this essay. Your encounter with a subject can matter through a choice of framing, duration, material, pairing, or voice. A relationship may make a detail important to you. A material process may teach you a distinction you could not have specified beforehand. The artistic contribution involves giving that knowledge a form through which someone else can encounter something of its significance.

Experience and artwork are therefore not interchangeable. Having lived through something does not settle how to represent it, and identifying the artist's social position does not explain every decision. Artists also learn through research, unfamiliar accounts, collaboration, and invention. Their position can develop as they work. The question is not "Does this artwork express my identity accurately enough?" but "What has this encounter made available to me, how has that changed the work, and what could make me reconsider it?" Situated authorship makes room for an informed, revisable contribution without demanding that the work become autobiography or speak for everyone.

A Real Memory, an Overbroad Claim

Donna Haraway

A feminist scholar of science and technology. Haraway argues for embodied, accountable knowledge rather than a supposedly neutral view from nowhere. Partiality is a condition of knowing, not an excuse to avoid testing a claim.

An invented teaching example

Imagine photographing your grandmother's house. As a child, you sat in a particular chair while she read to you. You return to that chair with a camera because your history makes it stand out. The resulting photographs try to give form to the welcome you remember.

You describe the series as a portrait of "a house where everyone felt at home." A cousin is surprised. They remember being scolded for touching the books you were allowed to choose freely. The room had a rule you never needed to notice. Your cousin's account does not prove that your feeling of welcome was false. It challenges your move from "I felt welcome" to "everyone felt welcome."

The next artistic decision need not be a disclaimer under an unchanged image. You might investigate the bookshelves, change the relation between chair and room, or pair photographs made from differently permitted positions. You could also decide the series concerns your particular memory rather than the household as a whole. Each response gives a different form to what you can establish.

This family scenario is invented for teaching. It is not Haraway's example, a biography of the artist, or documentation of an actual family. Its purpose is to separate the reality of an experience from the reach of a claim made through it.

A position is something you work from

The cousin's account matters because it is capable of changing the inquiry. Simply adding a second voice would not guarantee a complete picture. You still need to consider what was said, how it relates to the first account, and what the photographs now imply. Accountability happens through those decisions, not through accumulating enough viewpoints to claim that nothing remains unseen.

Keep the encounter specific: a permission, an observation, a conversation, a bodily habit, a resistance in the material. Then ask where it enters the form.

Making a Relation Perceptible

LaToya Ruby Frazier

Frazier's sustained work with her family and hometown of Braddock, Pennsylvania, connects intimate experience to the conditions of a place. *Landscape of the Body (Epilepsy Test)* is part of *The Notion of Family*.



LaToya Ruby Frazier, Landscape of the Body (Epilepsy Test), 2011. Complete diptych, from The Notion of Family. Whitney Museum of American Art; purchase, with funds from the Henry Nias Foundation, 2012.138a-b. Courtesy LaToya Ruby Frazier and Michel Rein, Paris/Brussels. Work/source record.

On the left, Frazier's mother undergoes medical testing. On the right, the Braddock hospital is being demolished. Wires attached to the body find a visual echo in cables hanging from the damaged building. The complete diptych matters: Frazier has made the relation between the photographs part of the work.

Family experience gives the loss of the hospital a particular urgency. Authorship also involves selecting, framing, and bringing the images together so that this loss can be encountered through a person's vulnerability and need for care. Familiarity does not automatically create that relation for a viewer; the artistic arrangement does work.

Haraway helps us describe why Frazier's involvement matters without treating biography as the complete explanation. This is a teaching interpretation, not a claim of direct theoretical influence. Nor do the photographs establish a medical cause for the mother's condition. Their force lies in a made relation between body, care, and place, not in proving every causal claim about those conditions.

Situated Does Not Mean Autobiographical

Sin Wai Kin

Sin works with film, performance, writing, and drag, constructing characters through learned and recombined conventions. *A Dream of Wholeness in Parts* brings drag into relation with Chinese operatic traditions, Taoist philosophy, and cinema.



Sin Wai Kin, A Dream of Wholeness in Parts, 2021. Film still. Courtesy of the artist and Soft Opening. Work/source record.

The costumed figure, dark rocks, water, and deliberate framing make this a staged encounter. Different viewers may recognize different conventions in the figure's appearance. Those associations have histories; recognizing them is not simply seeing gender or identity without interpretation.

Sin's knowledge of performance can generate an invented character rather than a portrait of their everyday self. Experience matters through decisions about appearance and staging. This is our Haraway-based reading, not a claim about Sin's stated theoretical influences. A still lets us inspect costume, setting, and framing; it does not establish the film's editing sequence or sound.

Where It Gets Complicated

An identity is not an automatic guarantee of truth, and an artist need not restrict their subject to lives they have lived. Research, work with a performer, or an unfamiliar account can alter a fictional scene. In abstraction, learned standards of clean edge, balance, and finish are also situated. A material test can give you a reason to revise them.

The test is not how much personal information the work discloses. Ask whether a particular encounter has changed what the work can show or investigate. A formal decision can acknowledge the reach of your knowledge without adding ambiguity merely to announce that you know your view is partial.

Studio Exercises

Three studio exercises: 2.1 Follow a Detail You Know · 2.2 Let Something Change Your Mind · 2.3 Construct a Viewpoint

Exercise 2.1: Follow a Detail You Know

Choose a detail in a current work that your experience has taught you to notice. It might concern a place, relationship, job, material behavior, gesture, or formal judgment.

1. Name how you learned to notice it. No personal disclosure is required.
2. Identify a decision in the work that depends on this knowledge.
3. Make a small study that gives the detail a different amount of space, duration, emphasis, or relation to something beside it.
4. Compare the versions. What can the new treatment make available to someone who does not share your familiarity?

The philosophical question: Experience matters to authorship through particular artistic decisions; the experience and the finished work are not the same thing.

What the artist leaves with: A changed treatment of a specific detail.

Exercise 2.2: Let Something Change Your Mind

Choose one assumption currently shaping a decision. For example: what counts as a good finish, what a familiar place means, or how a character would respond.

1. Write the assumption in a sentence.
2. Seek something capable of challenging it: a material test, a relevant first-person account, a source you have not considered, or a conversation someone has agreed to have.
3. Make a revised study that responds to what you actually learned.
4. Name what changed and what you still cannot establish. If the assumption survived, explain what tested it rather than manufacturing a reversal.

The philosophical question: A situated account becomes more accountable when it can respond to encounters it did not already contain.

What the artist leaves with: A revised study or a better-grounded decision to retain the original.

Try It in the Studio

Exercise 2.3: Construct a Viewpoint

Return to the detail or finding from the previous exercises. Give it a form that reflects how you came to know it. The work does not need to portray your everyday self.

1. Identify what the work can show or investigate through this particular encounter, and something that remains beyond it.
2. Make a new version whose choices respond to that reach. In fiction, decide what a character can know, discover, or misunderstand. In documentary work, reconsider what a framing or pairing implies. In abstraction, develop a relation discovered through the actual material test.
3. Compare the versions. Point to where the encounter changed the work's form, rather than adding an explanatory disclaimer afterward.
4. Carry one discovery into a finished small study. Do not add ambiguity simply to signal that you know your perspective is partial.

The philosophical question: A particular way of knowing can generate form and invention. Situated authorship does not require autobiography or a claim to represent the whole subject.

What the artist leaves with: A small study whose formal decisions grow from a specific, revisable encounter.

Where the encounter entered the form

Name the actual encounter: what your body, tool, access, relationship, or test let you notice. Point to the resulting decision in framing, material, duration, voice, or relation—not only a statement added afterward.

What I will carry into the next version

Go Further with the Framework

Use the accessible list to enter the argument; the further readings support closer study and direct critiques. Free access does not always mean easy prose.

Accessible Reading List

1. Monika Rogowska-Stangret — ***Situated Knowledges***
   Read the opening through Haraway's questions about how, where, and with whom to see. Explains the god trick, partial perspective, and accountability; the later, denser new-materialist genealogy is optional. **Free text**
2. Elizabeth Anderson — ***Feminist Epistemology and Philosophy of Science***
   Read sections 1, 3, and 8 for situated knowers, Haraway's accountable positioning, and competing meanings of objectivity. Distinguishes how a claim arises from whether it is warranted. **Free text**
3. Heidi Grasswick — ***Feminist Social Epistemology***
   Read sections 2–3 for socially differentiated knowers, relational inquiry, and objectivity as critical practice. Helps prevent situated knowledge from becoming a private viewpoint immune to correction. **Free text**
4. T. Bowell — ***Feminist Standpoint Theory***
   Read sections 3–5 and 7. Explains why a critically achieved standpoint is not automatically supplied by social identity, then introduces relativism and the bias paradox. A neighboring theory, not Haraway's position verbatim. **Free text**

Further Reading

1. Sandra Harding — ***Stronger Objectivity for Sciences From Below***
   Develops stronger standards of objectivity capable of exposing assumptions that ordinary 'good research' leaves intact. A substantive neighboring account of reflexivity and marginalized starting points, not a license to treat identity as evidence. **Free PDF**
2. Jasmin Trächtler — ***The world as witty agent—Donna Haraway on the object of knowledge***
   A close study of Haraway's knowing subject and active object of knowledge. Develops material-semiotic agency and the world's capacity to unsettle inquiry, resisting a reduction of situatedness to personal perspective. **Free PDF**
3. Tobias Engqvist — ***The Bias Paradox: Are Standpoint Epistemologies Self-contradictory?***
   Tests whether situated knowledge can coexist with better and worse justification. Its distinction between subjective and objective justification offers a technical defense against relativism; this is Engqvist's reconstruction, not Haraway's vocabulary. **Free PDF**
4. Donna Haraway — ***Situated Knowledges: The Science Question in Feminism and the Privilege of Partial Perspective***
   The demanding primary anchor. Begin with 'The Persistence of Vision': embodied, partial objectivity opposes both the god trick and relativism. Accountability means examining how a view is made, not merely announcing an identity. **Free PDF**

03 Art as Collective Activity

A work takes shape through other people's activities and shared conventions. Your contribution can be described within those relations.

OVERVIEW

Howard Becker's *Art Worlds*, published in 1982, approaches art through the activities that make it possible. Becker was a sociologist and working jazz pianist. Instead of beginning with a self-sufficient creator, he asks how people coordinate what they do: who develops an idea, supplies materials, realizes a form, prepares its presentation, and learns how to encounter it? The artist's contribution takes shape inside these relations rather than outside them.

For Becker, an **art world** is a network of people whose cooperative activities produce works of a particular kind. This is not simply a fashionable gallery scene or a committee that decides whether something counts as art. The network may include people the artist never meets. A person painting alone still relies on manufactured paint, inherited techniques, tools, and conventions of display. Those contributions affect what the painter can do without making every supplier a co-author of the painting.

Cooperation often depends on **conventions**: learned, shared ways of coordinating activities and decisions. A count-in lets musicians begin together; chord symbols communicate a structure while leaving room for interpretation. Print formats and marked-up proofs help an artist and printer coordinate a result. Scripts and lighting cues organize theatrical action. Framing and edition conventions help people prepare, identify, and handle objects. Some conventions are explicit, while others become so familiar that they feel like properties of the medium itself.

A convention enables work and shapes the range of work likely to be made. Departing from it can require more than an individual idea. A print beyond the available machine's width may need another process, a different printer, or a new way to join sections. The desired formal change may therefore depend on learning a skill, finding equipment, or agreeing on a procedure with another person. Understanding the working arrangement can reveal why an artistic possibility keeps meeting resistance.

Art worlds also distinguish their defining artistic activities from **support work**. A photographer may be recognized as the artist while a specialist printer's decisions are described as technical assistance. Becker gives us a reason to examine what each person actually decided before accepting the labels as a complete account. Who chose the paper? Who preserved detail in a dark area? Who could reject the proof? Authorship need not mean doing every task yourself. It can involve conceiving, selecting, arranging, and responding within collective production. But a precise account must also recognize other people's judgments, the terms under which they enter the work, and the differences between their roles.

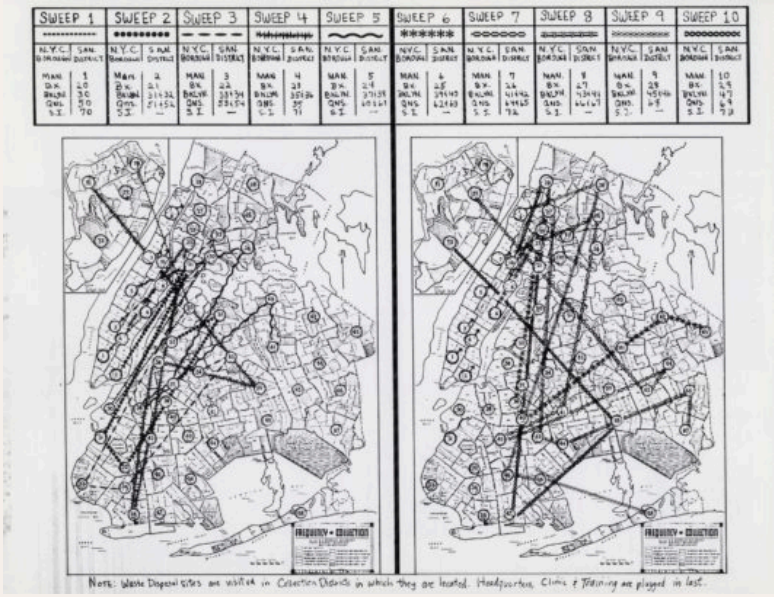
Thinkers and Artists from the Session

Howard Becker

Becker follows the practical organization of artistic activity. His experience as a musician informs an account of cooperation built from learned conventions, specialized contributions, and the work needed to coordinate them.

Mierle Laderman Ukeles

Ukeles makes maintenance and the labor sustaining everyday life available for recognition. *Touch Sanitation* brought a repeated face-to-face acknowledgment into New York City sanitation workers' existing places and patterns of work.



Mierle Laderman Ukeles, Touch Sanitation Performance, 1979–80. Itinerary map from the artist's invitation brochure, 1979. © Mierle Laderman Ukeles. Courtesy the artist and Ronald Feldman Gallery, New York. Work/source record.

An action with an itinerary

In *Touch Sanitation*, Ukeles traveled through the city's sanitation districts, shaking employees' hands and thanking them for keeping New York City alive. The action gave recognition a physical form: meeting workers where they worked rather than treating their labor as an invisible service.

The itinerary was not background administration added to an already complete idea. Department personnel's knowledge of districts, routes, and shifts helped determine where encounters could happen. Workers' participation made the proposed gesture an actual exchange. The brochure map documents organized journeys through that working system, not a photograph of the handshake itself.

Ukeles's proposal and sustained action remain identifiable artistic contributions. Describing the cooperation does not dissolve them. It helps explain how they became a work with a particular scale, duration, and form. We use Becker to examine this arrangement, without claiming that Ukeles designed the work as an illustration of his theory.

Describe the Judgment, Then the Role

The photographer and the specialist printer

A photographer chooses a subject, frames the image, and selects a photograph. A printer chooses how to translate it into a physical print: which paper can carry the tonal relation, how much contrast to introduce, and what should remain visible in a dark passage. Their decisions meet in what a viewer actually sees.

Calling the printer's work "technical assistance" identifies a familiar role, but does not tell us how much judgment it contains. Conversely, identifying that judgment does not by itself establish shared authorship. The practical questions are more precise: what was left open, who proposed an option, who approved it, and what did their agreement permit?

Move the printer's knowledge earlier in the process and the photographer may make a different selection. A difficult shadow may become printable; a paper's surface may invite a different scale. The artistic difference is not simply a new credit line. It can be a different result produced by a changed sequence of decisions.

Where It Gets Complicated

Collective production does not mean equal authorship, equal power, agreement, or equal benefit. A paint manufacturer, an artist conceiving a project, and a fabricator making formal judgments can all contribute without contributing in the same way. Calling everything collaboration can conceal these differences as readily as saying "I made it."

Cooperation describes how activities fit together, not necessarily a harmonious relationship. One person may be able to refuse a change while another cannot. A credit can recognize a contribution without correcting inadequate pay or transferring decision-making authority. Becker's account helps us begin asking about these matters; it does not automatically settle what each person should receive.

Start with one actual handoff rather than tracing every dependency in the work. Describe what arrived, what judgments were already in it, and what you did next. That account can show whether the next useful change concerns the object, an instruction, the timing of a conversation, or the working agreement itself.

The contribution can be yours without being self-sufficient. Specific roles make that claim clearer, not weaker.

Studio Exercises

Three studio exercises: 3.1 Follow One Handoff · 3.2 Change a Convention · 3.3 Bring Judgment in Earlier

Exercise 3.1: Follow One Handoff

Choose one point where another person's activity enters your work: a material, a proof, an installation decision, a performance instruction, or a process you learned.

1. Trace that handoff from what arrives to what you do with it.
2. Name a judgment already built into it and a judgment you add.
3. Identify one feature of the resulting work that depends on both.
4. Sketch or make a small alternative using a different handoff: an earlier proof, another material format, a changed instruction, or a conversation before the decision is fixed.

The philosophical question: Other people's contributions shape what the artist can decide; they are not only background assistance.

What the artist leaves with: A concrete account of one dependency and an alternative way of working with it.

Exercise 3.2: Change a Convention

Choose one familiar convention that helps your work get made: size, file format, sequence of steps, notation, finish, rehearsal method, or approval procedure.

1. Make one small test that departs from it.
2. Note what the departure requires: a different tool, new skill, more time, a revised instruction, or another person's agreement.
3. Compare the result with the conventional version.
4. Decide whether the artistic difference is worth changing the working arrangement.

The philosophical question: A convention makes cooperation possible and shapes its possibilities. Departing from it can require more than an individual idea.

What the artist leaves with: A test and an informed decision about the conditions needed to continue it.

Try It in the Studio

Exercise 3.3: Bring Judgment in Earlier

Choose a current or possible collaborator whose knowledge could affect an unresolved part of the work.

1. Mark which decisions are fixed and which remain open.
2. Identify one point where you normally ask this person to carry out a decision already made.
3. Agree on a small test in which their judgment can enter earlier, then run the revised sequence to produce a proof, rehearsal, sample, or other trial result.
4. Compare the results of the two arrangements. Be specific about whose decision made the difference.

If a collaborator is not available, bring an existing technical instruction, supplier's specification, or earlier piece of advice into the process before a decision is fixed, and run the test yourself. That can test the sequence, but it is not evidence of what an absent collaborator would choose. Do not assume unpaid availability or assign someone credit or responsibility without their agreement.

The philosophical question: Authorship can involve organizing how different judgments enter a work without making everyone's role identical.

What the artist leaves with: A trial result produced through a changed working arrangement.

The trial result / The judgment that changed it

Keep the proof, rehearsal, sample, or other result beside the earlier arrangement. Record whose actual decision made a difference. A solo sequence test does not establish what an absent collaborator would decide.

What I will carry into the next version

Go Further with the Framework

Use the accessible list to enter the argument; the further readings support closer study and direct critiques. Free access does not always mean easy prose.

Accessible Reading List

1. Volker Kirchberg and Tasos Zembylas — *Art Worlds as Collectives (chapter 2 of The Social Organization of Arts – A Theoretical Compendium)*
   Start with sections 2–4: cooperation, conventions, and divisions of labor. This substantial reference chapter explains Becker's vocabulary; section 7 introduces criticisms of the framework. **Free chapter**
2. Howard S. Becker — *Making it up as you go along: How I Wrote Art Worlds*
   Becker explains how music, photography, and participants' complaints led him to conventions and collective activity. A readable account of how to investigate the arrangements behind an artwork. **Free text**
3. Fernando Domínguez Rubio — *The Art We Do Together: "Art Worlds" 40th Anniversary*
   A clear introduction to Becker's shift from asking what art is to asking how art gets done, including the people, materials, standards, and institutions that coordinate production. **Free text**
4. Howard S. Becker — *Some Implications of the Equation Art=Work for the Sociology of Art*
   Follow the work upstream through decisions and downstream through its continuing history. Becker shows how different people's labor and negotiated judgments become part of an artwork's actual form. **Free text**

Further Reading

1. Howard S. Becker — *Art Worlds, 25th Anniversary Edition — chapters 1–2: "Art Worlds and Collective Activity" and "Conventions"*
   Read chapters 1–2 for the primary account of cooperative networks, artistic versus support work, and conventions. Departures from conventions require changes in resources, skills, and working relationships. **Library or purchase**
2. Howard S. Becker and Alain Pessin — *A Dialogue on the Ideas of "World" and "Field"*
   Becker and Pessin distinguish art worlds from Bourdieu's fields. Their discussion of conventions, conflict, support personnel, and open boundaries prevents cooperation from becoming a synonym for harmony or fairness. **Free text**
3. Howard S. Becker and Robert R. Faulkner — *"Do You Know . . . ?" The Jazz Repertoire: An Overview*
   A sustained empirical extension: musicians coordinate without rehearsal by negotiating partially shared repertoires. Follow how individual knowledge, selection, and performance situations qualify any simple account of shared conventions. **Free text**
4. Wendy Bottero and Nick Crossley — *Worlds, Fields and Networks: Becker, Bourdieu and the Structures of Social Relations*
   A direct critique of both Becker and Bourdieu. Network analysis makes cooperation's unequal opportunities, constraints, and positions more explicit without abandoning attention to concrete interactions. **Free PDF**

04 The Author as Producer

Artistic decisions can shape how work is produced, encountered, and used, including what others gain the means to make.

OVERVIEW

Walter Benjamin wrote *The Author as Producer* in 1934, in exile from Nazi Germany and in the context of Marxism, class struggle, and opposition to fascism. His question is more demanding than whether an artwork expresses a progressive opinion. He asks how the author operates within the organized conditions through which cultural work is made and circulated. A writer can condemn an institution while continuing to supply it with a product it already knows how to sell.

Benjamin's socialist commitment matters to the argument. He wants producers to help transform the **conditions of production**, including the division between those who produce culture and those who consume it. Politically critical content can be absorbed into an unchanged apparatus. A compelling image of misery may become an object of admiration or consumption without making its causes easier to understand or giving anyone greater means to act. Sincere opposition is therefore not sufficient evidence of a transformed productive relation.

His term **technique** connects artistic decisions to this problem. It includes procedures such as captioning, editing, combining images, staging, and interruption, as well as the tools and media that make those procedures possible. A caption can identify circumstances a photograph alone cannot establish. An interruption can turn attention from waiting for an outcome toward examining why it happens. Technique affects the task the work gives its audience; it is not merely a polished surface added to a political message.

Benjamin also asks whether producers give others greater capacity to produce. A publication might invite readers to send stories while reserving every editorial decision for its existing staff. Another arrangement might provide training, equipment, access to publication, and authority over selection. Both invite participation, but only the second begins to change what participants have the practical means to do. **Productive capacity** requires resources and room for judgment, not just an opportunity to respond.

For our authorship question, this opens a way to describe a contribution through how work is prepared, encountered, and used. These are possibilities to examine, not a demand that every artist turn every audience into producers. Benjamin's political ambition remains stronger than a general invitation to improve audience engagement. We can take that ambition seriously while distinguishing a work that makes a system visible from one that changes access or redistributes control. This is also a different Benjamin argument from Quarter 1's discussion of reproduction and aura. Here, the central issue is the author's position within production and the changes their technique makes possible.

Thinkers and Artists from the Session

Walter Benjamin

A German-Jewish philosopher and cultural critic who examined literature, photography, film, and the politics of cultural production. *The Author as Producer* asks what work does within productive arrangements, not only what position it declares.

Bertolt Brecht

A playwright and director whose epic theatre makes social situations available for examination. Songs, captions, and interruptions can let an audience care about characters while questioning the conditions shaping their choices.

Three photographic questions, not a ranking

Albert Renger-Patzsch, *The World Is Beautiful* (1928). Benjamin's own target is a photographic treatment that can make nature, objects, and industry visually fascinating without exposing the relations organizing production. Admiring a factory's forms does not tell us who controls it or under what conditions people work.

Dorothea Lange, *Migrant Mother* (1936). This later example invites a different inquiry. Lange's government documentary work and reporting about the camp connected images to information about workers' conditions. Rather than dismissing sympathy as consumption, ask what captions, reporting, and institutions made possible. The photograph's fame alone does not establish its precise effect.

The Abu Ghraib prisoner photograph (2003). The image was made within the abuse by a member of the U.S. military, not as a critical artist's intervention. Its later circulation as evidence gave it a political use its maker had not intended. We discuss it without reproducing it here. Exposure and institutional change remain different outcomes.

Only the first is Benjamin's own example; the other two are later applications. They distinguish treatment, reporting, and circulation rather than sorting images into political failures and successes.

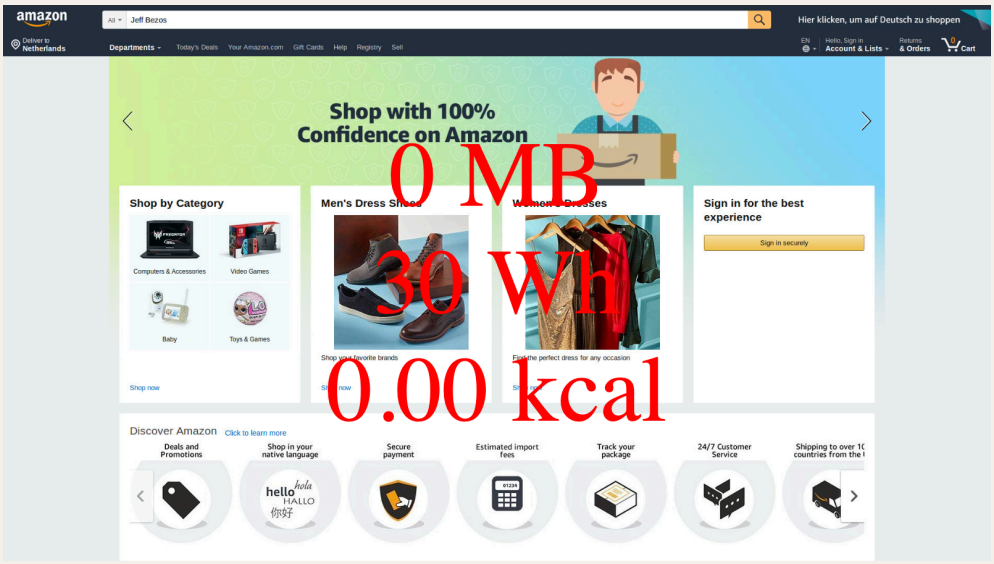
An interruption changes the audience's task

Hypothetical teaching scene—not a scene from Brecht: a worker accepts a dangerous job. Suspense may direct us toward whether they survive. Now imagine a projected caption announces their death before the action begins. Knowing the outcome can redirect attention toward why they accepted, what alternatives existed, and who judged the risk acceptable. The interruption changes what there is to examine; it does not guarantee what each spectator concludes.

Begin with the Familiar Transaction

Joana Moll

An artist and researcher investigating the internet's infrastructure, surveillance, and environmental costs. In *The Hidden Life of an Amazon User*, a reconstructed purchase makes background computational activity part of the encounter. Technical development: Ramin Soleymani.



Joana Moll, The Hidden Life of an Amazon User, 2019. Purchase-interface view of the online artwork. Technical development: Ramin Soleymani. Work/source record.

In 2019, Moll bought a book about Jeff Bezos through Amazon and traced what her browser loaded during the purchase. Alongside the shopping pages were layers of code supporting the interface, its interactions, and the recording of user activity. The online artwork reconstructs that transaction as material a viewer moves through by scrolling.

The storefront view matters because it gives us an ordinary point of entry: a recognizable purchase rather than an abstract diagram of an unfamiliar system. The work then brings activity normally kept in the background into the time and space of the encounter. Its data and energy counters belong to the artwork's modeled account; they are estimates, not independent live measurements of a reader's device.

Locating the author within production

The following orientation unpacks the session's argument. These are not four formal stages Benjamin sets out; they can overlap and loop back.

Making
Developing form and content with available tools, skills, and resources.

Selecting and preparing
Editing, rehearsing, choosing, and deciding what form will be shared.

Presenting and circulating
Arranging where the work appears and on what terms people can encounter it.

Encountering and using
Reading, responding, inspecting, adapting, or making something further.

What Scrolling Brings into View



Joana Moll, The Hidden Life of an Amazon User, 2019. Underlying-code view of the online artwork. Technical development: Ramin Soleymani. Work/source record.

Farther down the same work, code fills the screen. The change from storefront to code is not merely a second illustration of the same point. It changes the viewer's task. An ordinary shopping interface helps a user complete a purchase quickly. Moll's reconstruction makes the amount of background material and the effort of moving through it part of what is encountered.

We need not read every line to examine the contrast between the apparently simple transaction and the activity it depends on. Selection, sequence, scrolling, and visible information give the reader material with which to question that simplicity. Moll's contribution includes arranging material she did not originate so it can be scrutinized differently. The two views here document different states of the interactive work, not an interactive experience inside the PDF. Visit the online artwork to encounter its scrolling procedure.

Where It Gets Complicated

Making parts of Amazon's operation available for scrutiny does not give viewers control over its infrastructure or the means to become producers themselves. This boundary belongs next to the analysis, not in a distant disclaimer. Visibility, understanding, practical access, productive capacity, and redistributed control are different achievements.

An artist can change a sequence, share a usable method, or give collaborators authority without being able to transform the larger institution. Benjamin's demand sharpens the question of what the arrangement actually enables. It should not become a checklist making every valuable artwork responsible for achieving all these changes. Describe the contribution and its limit together; then choose one condition genuinely within reach.

Studio Exercises

Three studio exercises: 4.1 Change What Can Be Examined · 4.2 Try Another Route · 4.3 Make a Usable Starting Point

Exercise 4.1: Change What Can Be Examined

Choose one place where a current work directs attention: a caption, reveal, transition, edit, sequence, or instruction.

1. Identify something about the situation that a viewer cannot establish from the existing encounter alone.
2. Make another version that provides a way to examine it: reveal a source, show a consequential step, interrupt the sequence, or bring two pieces of evidence into relation.
3. Compare what each version actually makes available to understand. Do not assume that additional explanation is always better.
4. Choose which version better serves the work, and name a limit on what it establishes.

The philosophical question: Technique can change the task an artwork gives its audience, not merely its appearance or emotional tone.

What the artist leaves with: Two versions of an encounter and a specific account of their difference.

Exercise 4.2: Try Another Route

Choose one work or a small component you are authorized to share.

1. Follow its current route to one real or privately staged encounter. Try a specific action: obtaining it, inspecting a source, using an allowed component, or proposing a change.
2. Identify one condition that enables or blocks that action, such as location, price, format, equipment, permission, or an approval decision. Name who can change that condition.
3. Prototype a second route that changes it, then repeat the action. A printed extract, different file format, or revised permission may be enough; public release is not required.
4. Record what the prototype actually enabled and what remains untested or outside your control. Decide whether the change serves the work.

The philosophical question: Circulation is part of a work's conditions of use. Availability, practical access, and the capacity to make something are not interchangeable.

What the artist leaves with: A tested access or use condition, a small circulation prototype, and its remaining limits.

Try It in the Studio

Exercise 4.3: Make a Usable Starting Point

Choose a small method, score, source set, or procedure from your work that you have the right to share. Test this possibility without assuming your whole practice must become participatory.

1. Prepare enough material and instruction for another person to try it.
2. State what they can decide or adapt, what tools or skills they need, and what use is permitted.
3. Invite a willing person to test it, or rehearse it yourself while explicitly noting that independent usability remains untested.
4. Revise the point where the procedure depends on knowledge or authority only you possess.

The philosophical question: Showing a process or collecting a response does not necessarily give someone the means to produce. A usable starting point requires practical resources and room for judgment.

What the artist leaves with: A tested or explicitly provisional score, method, or source set, with its remaining dependencies named.

What the test enabled / What still depends on me

Record what a willing tester actually managed to make or decide. If you rehearsed the method yourself, name the dependency you changed and keep independent usability explicitly untested.

What I will carry into the next version

Go Further with the Framework

Use the accessible list to enter the argument; the further readings support closer study and direct critiques. Free access does not always mean easy prose.

Accessible Reading List

1. Andy McLaverty-Robinson — *Walter Benjamin: Culture and Revolution — "The Author as Producer" section*
   Read "The Author as Producer": intellectual work is inside production, and radical themes alone do not transform its apparatus. Connects producer–audience divisions, photography, and Brecht's theatre in plain language. **Free text**
2. Terry Eagleton — *Understanding Brecht (review)*
   A short, direct explanation of why Benjamin asks about the artist's position within production. Connects Brecht's epic theatre to changing the theatrical apparatus rather than merely supplying revolutionary stories. **Free text**
3. Ellen Lupton — *The Designer as Producer*
   Introduces Benjamin through design: manufacture, captions, distribution, and the reader–producer divide. Useful for concrete studio questions, while distinguishing Lupton's contemporary educational adaptation from Benjamin's revolutionary political demand. **Free text**
4. Andrea Phillips — *Annotation on 'The Author as Producer' in Walter Benjamin: Selected Writings, Vol. 2, Part 2, 1931–1934*
   A brief guide to political tendency, artistic quality, and institutions' ability to absorb radical themes. Phillips connects Benjamin's problem to contemporary curatorial judgments without resolving aesthetic value into social usefulness. **Free text**

Further Reading

1. Gerald Raunig — *Changing the Production Apparatus: Anti-Universalist Concepts of Intelligentsia in the early Soviet Union*
   Reconstructs Benjamin's distinction between supplying content and changing production through Tretyakov's organizational experiments. Examines specialist knowledge, collective capacities, and the limits of the intellectual who claims to speak for everyone. **Free PDF**
2. Boris Buden — *Re-Reading Benjamin's 'Author as Producer' in the Post-Communist East*
   Challenges effortless updates of Benjamin after state socialism. Asks what happens to the producer argument when its revolutionary institutions, historical experience, and shared method can no longer be assumed. **Free PDF**
3. Andrea Phillips — *Too Careful: Contemporary Art's Public Making*
   Read especially pages 53–56: Phillips revisits Benjamin's producer demand against the rhetoric of care and collaboration, questioning whether artistic politics requires direct social repair or can work through formal reconfiguration. **Free PDF**
4. Walter Benjamin — *The Author as Producer (1934; translated by John Heckman, 1970)*
   The primary argument: examine a work's position within production, not only its political message. Read especially the passages on technique, transforming the apparatus, Brecht's interruptions, and enabling other producers. **Free text**

One Work, Four Questions

PRACTICE SYNTHESIS

An Authorship Map

Use the same finished or in-progress work across all four panels. Stay close to decisions and relations you can point to. These are different accounts of authorship, not four requirements to satisfy.

Foucault

What does its attribution to me make people connect or expect?

Haraway

What has my position made available to notice, and what could revise my view?

Becker

Which judgments are mine, and how have other people's activities shaped what I could do?

Benjamin

What do the ways I make and share it allow others to understand or do?

Circle the question that exposes a decision you want to revisit. Choose one small experiment from the toolkit, or design your own. If the frameworks pull toward different decisions, name the tension and choose which question to pursue in this test.

My contribution here includes...

One decision I want to test is...

I will compare...

A contribution can be real without being self-sufficient. This is a working account of one piece, not a compulsory artist statement or a test of whether you deserve to call it yours.

KEEP THE LANGUAGE CLOSE AT HAND

Glossary of Key Terms

Author-function
The organizing role of attribution in grouping, interpreting, and treating works. Foucault distinguishes this function from the whole life of the person who makes them.

Attribution
Identifying a person or entity as the author of a work. Attribution has interpretive and practical consequences without settling every question about the work.

Body of work
Works brought into relation as part of an artistic practice. The connections can be selected, challenged, and revised.

Situated knowledge
Knowledge made possible and limited by a particular position and way of encountering the world, including bodies, tools, training, relationships, and access.

God trick
Haraway's term for the claim to see from nowhere, without accounting for the position and means through which one's own view is produced.

Partial perspective
A view that is located and incomplete, and can be examined and revised. Partiality does not imply that all accounts are equally well supported.

Art world, in Becker's sense
People whose cooperative activities make works of a particular kind possible. The network can reach beyond those personally known to the artist.

Convention
A learned, shared way of coordinating activities and decisions. Conventions make cooperation easier and shape which departures require new arrangements.

Support work
Activities an art world distinguishes from its defining artistic work. The label does not establish an absence of judgment or determine how a contribution should be credited.

Conditions of production
The organized material and social conditions through which work is made: resources, divisions of labor, institutions, and decision-making arrangements.

Technique, in Benjamin's argument
The procedures and technical means through which work is made and presented, including captioning, editing, staging, and interruption.

Circulation
The routes and arrangements through which work reaches people and enters new uses. Location, price, format, and permission can all matter.

Productive capacity
The practical means, knowledge, and room for decision that enable someone to make something. An invitation to respond does not necessarily provide this capacity.

Epic theatre
Brecht's approach to presenting and interrupting events so audiences can examine the social conditions shaping them, rather than only waiting for the outcome.

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